



CHAPTER 7 PERFORMANCE ON THE ROCK

PHOTO: JOSH LARSON

Rock climbing is what we love, and climbing well just gives us more to love. When you are strong and fit, climbing gives a sense of confidence and freedom that is unmatched. Although you can integrate your climbing outside into these programs with some success, I have found that trying to match the planned demands of a training day out on the rock is hard for most people. Many of us do not have the varying difficulties, lengths, and types of moves at our crag that are needed for steady progress in training. We enjoy climbing routes for their aesthetics more than for their physical demands, and we almost always share climbing days with friends. Our friends might not want or need to do the same type of training day we do.

I firmly believe that you can have an effective program where the climbing somewhat follows the training, but is not integrated directly into it. There is a time and a place for concentrated non-crag training, such as mid-winter, or during the hottest months, but I want these programs to work for you year-round, and I want you to feel like you can “train” even during peak climbing times.

As I wrote earlier, the nonlinear method works best simply by increasing the volume of your training as you ramp up to times you want to perform. Block programming allows you to supercharge certain performance factors, and you can “peak” several times a year. With increased attention to training, your technique, strength, and endurance naturally improve. But during these training increases, what do we do when we get to the crag? How best to match training with performance?

Progress in climbing best occurs by climbing more or harder or both. What we want to do is to lay the foundations of progress through training and then get better at climbing by climbing. In order for this to happen, you're going to want to be as focused and driven at the crag as you are at the gym. You're going to have to build some structure in each and every climbing day. If you go to the crag with nothing planned, it's more than likely that "nothing" will happen.

GOAL SETTING

I have always liked the saying, "If you don't know where you are going, any road will get you there." In climbing, our motivation for the sport comes largely from the routes that inspire us. Some of these routes appeal to us because of their aesthetics, some because of location, but most because of what they represent to us in terms of difficulty. It's hard *not* to be inspired by the idea of climbing Midnight Lightning or free climbing a big wall. It's the image of completing something we could just barely do that makes redpointing so attractive to so many of us.

With this in mind, I suggest approaching your climbing with two levels of goals in mind. The first are *short-term* goals, the step-by-step progress routes which we tend to pick as projects. The second are *stretch* goals - dream routes that inspire you through the arduous days of training and visits to your local crag.

There are downfalls to each type of goal setting, and a heavy bias toward one or the other can derail your progress. For example, if you get over-interested in training and building up your base, you risk halting progress. If you rigidly adhere to a redpoint pyramid or are a project-only climber, you can spend season after season stuck reaching, losing, and getting back to the same level.

If you spend entire seasons working a project that is too far outside your abilities, you might not get anywhere. We all know that you need to try hard routes to climb hard routes, but if you reach too far, your ability to bridge the gap between your current level and your dream routes will be limited. Moreover, you risk detraining (hanging on every bolt, every time is bad for fitness) and injury (moves too hard too soon can beat you up).

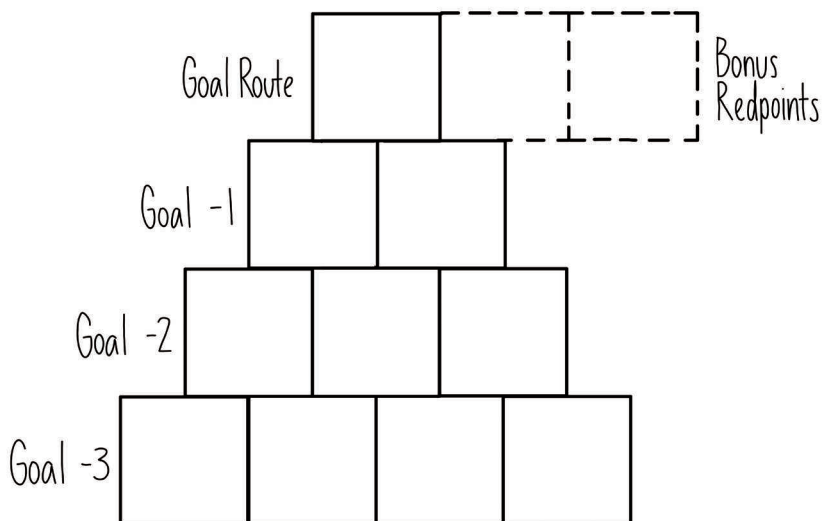
This is where a combination of two kinds of goals is magic. By setting several goals for this year that are hard but achievable, you can set yourself up for success on the big goal in a few years. The big goal can't just be a dream, though. You will want to actively engage in getting there by climbing on the route itself or similar routes, by developing the strength, power, or endurance necessary for the route, and by building mental models of what the dream route is going to take.

PYRAMIDS

The redpoint pyramid is a great tool for visualizing your climbing progress. Many versions of this have been suggested over the years, but I recommend a very simple version here. The pyramid can be a good motivator, but can also work against you if you try to use it too often. The basic idea is to draw out a pyramid of several boxes, with a single box at the top, then several layers of boxes below, as seen in the figure below.

The pyramid is structured to help climbers in two ways: to help assure that they are developing enough base fitness for goal routes, and to make sure they are pushing their goals forward. Additionally, by adhering to the rule of logging only redpoint (and onsight/flash) ascents, it helps less experienced or fearful climbers get used to leading and the process of sending.

I like a simple 4-3-2-1 pyramid. Since the training in the Logical Progression programs is not built in long phases, the redpointing



progresses separately from the training and shorter cycles work better. In a block plan, you might stick with bouldering through the power and strength phases, but then climb routes in endurance phases. In most block programs, I suggest starting into the redpoint pyramid at the beginning of the power endurance phase, so that as that phase closes and you enter performance, you are close to the top of the pyramid.

In the mindset of natural increases at the crag, your progressions can be smoother and more “organic.” Many people arrive at the top of the pyramid quickly, and can have several weeks of great fitness. If you’re still feeling great after you redpoint your goal route on the pyramid, I suggest doing another. You’re going to be able to hold peak fitness for at least 3 weeks, and you might as well make the most of them if you send your goal route in week one! That’s where the dashed boxes at the top come in. Frequently, we see a climber send two or three routes at the top of a peak, and I don’t want to make an arbitrary rule to keep that from happening.

PROJECTING

Project climbing is the magical realm of redpointing. It's where you push yourself not only physically, but emotionally and mentally as well. Projects are what drive our motivation, and they are the routes by which we mark our seasons. In the end, these are the routes that will define your career as a redpoint climber.

These climbs should be selected on two levels. You should have projects that fit with the climbing season and with the crags where you plan to climb. These should push you slightly, and should continue to increase in difficulty through your career. You should also have dream routes that you visit occasionally. These routes are the ones that get you up in the morning and keep you up at night. They are the ones you'd quit work for. They are the ones by which you might define whole periods of your life.

I am adamant that seasonal projects fall quickly. The entire point of the redpoint pyramid is to prepare you mentally and physically to send these routes fast. When you pick a season project, your early focus should still be climbing routes on lower tiers of the pyramid. Every 6 or 7 climbing days, it's good to visit the season project to check your fitness, learn moves, and keep the goal in mind. A good season of projecting would then look like this:

3 out of 5 climbing days: Redpointing routes on your current redpoint pyramid.

1 out of 5 climbing days: A less-focused, fun day of volume climbing.

1 out of 7 climbing days: Checking out the top tier projects.

THE MAGICAL SECOND TIER

There is a fundamentally important zone along the redpoint pyramid that we call the "second tier." These are simply the routes that fall one tier below your current highest project level. These are

climbs that are hard enough to really push you, but are ones you can send in a few tries. In short, they are in the “sweet-spot” for accelerated learning.

Unfortunately, these are the very routes many of us overlook. The majority of us know when we are in top form. This usually occurs right about the time you hit the second tier, and many of us decide to go right to projecting. A quick perusal of the bottom-end of the 8a.nu rankings will show you the result: one or two hard redpoints at a climber’s top grade followed by single sends or no sends in the 2-3 grades below.

Look higher up the 8a rankings, and you start to see the reality: elite climbers do not ignore their base. The grades just below their limits are numerous. If your goal is to get better, not just “have climbed 12a,” you should focus hard on the routes that will get you there.

VOLUME CLIMBING

Volume climbing is simply a lower-intensity day on the rock, where you work to do more mileage than on a typical redpoint day. We use these days to help groove good movement patterns and to maintain a decent level of fitness. On a redpoint-only plan, climbers tend to climb themselves out-of-shape by limiting the amount of climbing they do in order to top out performance. By keeping volume in the mix just once every couple of weeks, you can effectively extend peak fitness - sometimes doubling the number of weeks you are sending hard.

